Freed Between the Lines

By Billy Collins, Belissa Escobedo, Rhiannon McGavin, Zariya Allen and Ellen Hopkins

Rain by Billy Collins

(Pg 1) Some time after the books had been forbidden—
The one about the woman and her daughter,
The one about the boy who spoke poorly—
And after the smoke from the incinerators had cleared,

It was suggested that censorship be extended
To the plover, the wild turkey, and the common moorhen.
But these birds have done nothing, a few protested.
That is precisely the problem, the loudspeakers answered.

It rained that month day and night. . .
Teachers disappeared on the way to their cars.

Then the committee came after the morning glory
For its suggestive furling and unfurling
And the ligustrum and the alstroemeria

4NG Fanatics

Because they were difficult to pronounce and spell.
Then the pine tree for its tricky needles and cones
And parsley and red and yellow peppers for no reason at all. . .

And the rain was constant and cold—fine days
to curl up with a good book, someone joked—
but there were no more books,
just the curling up of people quietly in corners and doorways,

bits of straw floating down the streets
along the curbs into the turbulent rivers and out to sea.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Billy Collins
Book: Censorship and Banned Books, Volume 3, Issue 1
ISBN: Magazine
Publisher: Random House, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): 2009
On-Line Location:
https://issuu.com/rhacademic/docs/rhi3

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

INTRODUCTION

Book banning and censorship are nothing new, but you may have noticed more discussion lately in the news and on social media. It's important to know that while some schools or communities may ban books, it does not make them illegal. Sometimes a ban on a book makes it just that much more, well, **intriguing**.

As parents and school boards lead the effort to erase uncomfortable interpretations of reality: Some examples? the Holocaust book Maus, *discussions of gender identity in George M. Johnson's* All Boys Aren't Blue, *and provocative stories that could lead to political questioning --* The Handmaid's Tale, *anyone? -- they are not only limiting access but also perpetuating inequalities and dictating what stories have the right to be heard.*

In the words of author Stephen Chbosky, "Banning books gives us silence when we need speech. It closes our ears when we need to listen. It makes us blind when we need sight."

It's time we Freed Between the Lines with poems by Billy Collins; Belissa Escobedo, Rhiannon McGavin, Zariya Allen; and Ellen Hopkins.

Somewhere in America by Belissa Escobedo, Rhiannon Mcgavin, and Zariya Allen

Here in America, in every single state, they have a set of standards for every subject

4NG Fanatics

A collection of lessons that the teacher's required to teach by the end of the term

But the greatest lessons you'll ever teach us will not come from your syllabus.

The greatest lessons you will ever teach us, you will not even remember

You never told us what we weren't allowed to say

We just learned how to hold our tongues

Now somewhere in America, there is a child holding a copy of "Catcher in the Rye" and there is a child holding a gun.

But only one of these things have been banned by their state government

And it's not the one that can rip through flesh

It's the one that says "f*** you" on more pages than one

Because we must control what the people say, and how they think.

And if they want to become the overseer of their own selves, then we'll show them a real one

And somewhere in America, there's a child sitting at his mother's computer reading the homepage of the KKK's website and that's open to the public

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

But that child will have never read “To Kill a Mockingbird” because his school has banned it for its use of the “N” word

Maya Angelou is prohibited because we’re not allowed to talk about rape in school
We were taught that “just because something happens, doesn’t mean you are to talk about it”
They build us brand-new shopping malls so that we’ll forget where we’re really standing
On the bones of the Hispanics, on the bones of the slaves, on the bones of the Native Americans, on the bones of those who fought just to speak!

Transcontinental Railroad to Japanese Internment Camps
There are things missing from our history books
But we were taught that it is better to be silent, than to make them uncomfortable
Somewhere in America, private school girls search for hours through boutiques, trying to find the prom dress of their dreams

4NG Fanatics

While kids on the south side spend hours searching through the ‘lost and found’ ’cause winter’s coming soon and that’s the only jacket they have

Kids are late to class for working the midnight shift
They give awards for best attendance, but not for keeping your family off the streets
These kids will call your music “ghetto,” they will tell you you don’t talk right
Then they’ll get in the backseat of a car with all their friends singing about how “They’re ‘bout that life” and “we can’t stop”
Somewhere in America, schools are promoting self confidence
While they whip out their scales and shout out your body fat percentage in class

Where heftier girls are hiding away, and the slim fit beauties can’t help but giggle with pride
The preppy kids go thrift shopping ‘cause they think it sounds real fun
But we go because that’s all we’ve got money for

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

'Cause Momma works for the city, momma only gets paid once a month

Somewhere in America, a girl is getting felt up by a grown man on the subway

She's still in her school uniform and that's part of the appeal

It's hard to run in knee-socks and Mary-Janes, and all her male teachers know it too.

Coaches cover up star-players raping freshmen after the dance

Women are killed for rejecting dates, but God forbid I bring my girlfriend to prom

Girls black out drunk at the after-party, take a picture before her wounds wake her

How many pixels is your sanity worth? What's a 4.0 to a cold jury?

What'd you learn in class today?

Don't walk fast, don't speak loud, keep your hands to yourself, keep your head down

Keep your eyes on your own paper, if you don't know the answer, fill in 'c'

4NG Fanatics

Always wear ear buds when you ride the bus alone

If you feel like someone's following you, pretend you're on the phone

The teacher never fails, only you do

Every state in America, the greatest lessons are the ones you don't remember learning.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Authors: ***Belissa Escobedo, Rhiannon Mcgavin, and Zariya Allen***
Book: On-Line Transcript Only
Publisher: Genius.com / Get Lit
Date (Month/Year): July 25, 2014
On-Line Location: https://genius.com/Get-lit-somewhere-in-america-annotated

Video of Live Performance can be found at:
2014 Brave New Voices (Finals)
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OadZpUJv8Eq

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Manifesto by Ellen Hopkins

You say you're afraid for children,
innocents ripe for corruption
by perversion or sorcery on the page.
But sticks and stones do break
bones, and ignorance is no armor.

You say you're afraid for America,
the red, white and blue corroded
by terrorists, socialists, the sexually
confused. But we are a vast quilt
of patchwork cultures and multi-gendered
identities. You cannot speak for those
whose ancestors braved
different seas.
You say you're afraid for God,
the living word eroded by Muhammed
and Darwin and Magdalene.
But the omnipotent sculptor of heaven
and earth designed intelligence.
Surely you dare not speak

4NG Fanatics

for the father, who opens
his arms to all.
A word to the unwise.
Torch every book.
Char every page.
Burn every word to ash.
Ideas are incombustible . . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ellen Hopkins
ISBN: Poster
On-Line Location: https://ncac.org/wp-content/uploads/import/BBWManifesto(1).pdf
Publisher: Simon & Schuster Children's Publishing
Date (Month/Year): 2009, 2010 and 2011

AWARD HISTORY

2024 National Qualifier – MS